focus group to discuss citizenship were excited about Imran Khan and the PTI, none were actually registered to vote, less than six months before the elections. This illustrates that many of those who would have possibly voted for Imran Khan were not registered voters, underlining that the system is not recognized or understood, placing political participation in the realm of media debates, away from true political participation. This could possibly be due to the fact that the lawyers' movement in which the youth was engaged simply petered out. However, there were still bouts of public anger, such as the fury in 2010 about the government's slow response to the catastrophic floods across Pakistan. Between 2011 and 2012 due to frequent power outages and breakdowns there were protests in different cities across Pakistan. These, however, do not translate into larger political activity – not even into anti-state movements.[20] Kugelman (2012) has written on the role that patronage plays, reiterating Lyon (2002) and Lieven's (2011) ideas that many, including the younger generation, would hesitate to change the political order in a way that could threaten the structure they depend on for future influence. Although the young people did not mention this explicitly, their families would caution about too radical a change.[21] Neither does Kugelman (2012) believe that anger and alienation could translate into a youth-led, religion-based political movement, despite many young people being in general anti-government and anti-American, with a majority favouring an Islamic government.

Given the history depicted so far in this chapter, it is not surprising to find a disconnect between the wider student population and politics in Pakistan. However, the extent of this disconnect, where political illiteracy[22] is the norm, where political activism, especially in government universities, is associated with violence, is highly problematic. Added to this is of course the problem of terrorism (see Chapter 4) that further creates a fear of public protest. This section unpacks all of these problems associated with political activism and participation among the youth, beginning with an analysis of the meaning and understanding of political activism by young students, their understanding of political awareness and level of political activism, and their perception about politics and political parties in Pakistan.

Politics and the Pakistani youth

Across the various interview and focus groups, corruption and lack of trust were one of the main reasons cited by young people for not getting involved in politics. Other reasons cited included the need for family connections, the